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Promoting boundary-spanning behavior among service personnel

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this model is to explain how person – organization fit (P – O fit) and competitive intensity, conceptualized as a job resource and a job demand, respectively, ultimately affect the development of frontline employee boundary-spanning behavior (BSB).

Design/methodology/approach – A survey methodology was used in collecting data from a sample of bank employees in South Korea. To analyze the data, a structural equation model procedure using LISREL 8.5 was used (Jöreskog and Sörbom, 1996).

Findings – Results suggest that a frontline employee's P – O fit decreases emotional exhaustion and increases achievement-striving motivation. Competitive intensity significantly reduces achievement-striving motivation. Results also show that competitive intensity significantly attenuates the positive relationship between P – O fit and employee achievement-striving motivation, highlighting the importance of contextual industry stressors upon internal organizational behaviors. Both emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation are found to ultimately affect BSBs except for the link between emotional exhaustion and service delivery.

Originality/value – The current study applies the job-demands resources model to demonstrate how both an externally initiated job demand (competitive intensity) and an internally oriented job resource (person – organization fit) influence employee experience of emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation. Interaction effects of P – O fit and competitive intensity on employee's psychological states (emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation) are also examined. Further, it is demonstrated that both emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation will directly influence service employee boundary-spanning behaviors, but in differential manners. This highlights the importance of exhaustion and motivation as mediators for the ultimate effect of a job resource (P – O fit), answering a call for such understanding of the developmental process for BSBs (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2000). This is the first empirical study to link both internal and external elements to illuminate the process for developing job demands and resources, as well as boundary spanning behaviors.

Keywords Emotional exhaustion, Person – organization fit, Boundary-spanning behavior, Achievement-striving motivation

Paper type Research paper



Introduction

As a specific type of boundary employee (bridging the company and the customer), customer service employees contribute to product and service excellence in varied manners. For example, effective service employees deliver on the promises of the firm, create a favorable image for the firm, go beyond the call of duty for customers and positively promote the firm's products (Bettencourt and Brown, 1997). Indeed, because of the relationship of service excellence to going above and beyond one's formal role, Bettencourt *et al.* (2001) developed the boundary-spanning behavior (BSB) concept to investigate the effects of truly exceptional service. BSB contends that service employees achieve excellence through three key areas: actual service delivery (akin to key elements of service quality provision), external representation (being outstanding advocates of the company to external constituents) and internal influence (being an internal champion for developing service excellence across the company). Empirical research has generally provided support for the valuable contribution of the BSB construct to our understanding of service excellence, and has accordingly proposed the positive effect of BSB on positive customer and firm outcomes (Bettencourt and MacKenzie, 2005).

In relation to the actual development of BSB, however, there is much to learn. Although employee attitudes, beliefs and/or psychological states are certainly acknowledged as potential keys to the development of BSB (Bettencourt and MacKenzie, 2005), few studies have been devoted to a specific, detailed understanding of the nature of developing such effects (i.e. the specific linkage of positive employee states to BSB). Indeed, as researchers and practitioners, we still do not have a clear picture regarding what psychological states, for example, may spur (hinder) BSB among service employees, thereby facilitating (hampering) spillover effects onto positive behavioral outcomes (Bettencourt and MacKenzie, 2005). Psychological states are relevant in relation to employee behaviors because the effect of environmental factors may have upon the development and associated outcomes of such states. For example, although a given state (e.g. motivation) may be fairly constant, the strength of development is actually dynamic in response to environmental context (Reigeluth, 1983). This distinguishes a state from a personality trait, where the trait would tend to dominate regardless of context (Reigeluth, 1983). Therefore, one goal of this research is to investigate and explain potentially key psychological drivers of BSB that are exhibited among service personnel.

To accomplish this research goal, the appropriate theoretical lens must be applied. One useful lens through which to view this issue is that of a job demands-resources (JD-R) model. JD-R models seek to explain employee psychological predictors of job behaviors through a balanced approach that investigates both negative (e.g. burnout), as well as positive (e.g. work engagement) aspects of psychological states by linking the states to both harmful, stress-related processes, as well as motivational processes (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007). In addition, previous JD-R research demonstrates that employee emotional exhaustion and/or work engagement is determined by environmental resources (Hobfoll, 1989). Schaufeli and van Rhenen (2009) suggest that, according to the motivational process of JD-R, work environments offer abundant resources that foster the development of positive employee psychological states that facilitate the successful completion of work tasks.

In this study, JD-R is integrated with the concepts of person – organization (P – O) fit and competitive intensity. Although there are varied conceptualizations of P – O fit

across different literatures, there is a consistency in belief that P – O fit represents, “compatibility between commensurate individual and organizational characteristics”, be they related to values, goals or attitudes (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005, p. 285). Given the importance placed upon the effects of compatible values in recent studies, however, the current research emphasizes compatibility of values as the foundation for P – O fit (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005).

The level of competitive intensity is indicated by the number of competitors and the frequency and intensity of using certain marketing techniques to gain market share. Hirschman (1970) considers competition as a major driver of a firm’s desire to provide quality products and services to its customers. Competitive intensity invites firms to be more exploratory and innovative (Auh and Menguc, 2007). Given today’s highly competitive environment, coupled with the underlying presence of competitive pressures in service employees’ job role, the impact of perceived competitive intensity on employees’ psychological states is very important.

In the current study, research on P – O fit and competitive intensity is advanced by exploring the effects of P – O fit and competitive intensity upon the service employee’s psychological states of emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation. In this context, *emotional exhaustion* is defined as the employee’s perception of his/her work as being the root cause of feelings of emotional overextension and/or exhaustion (Maslach and Jackson, 1981). *Achievement-striving motivation* is defined as an employee’s perception of his/her desired intention to engage in planned actions to achieve beneficial, work-related tasks. Emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation were selected for investigation due to their prominence within service industry settings (Bettencourt and MacKenzie, 2005; Hobfoll, 1989), as the nature of frequent customer contact can be both draining, as well as motivating, representing a delicate balance between negative and positive psychological states of mind.

Emotional exhaustion represents a negative intervening mechanism, while achievement-striving motivation is positive, which helps explain the proposed effects of P – O fit and competitive intensity on a service employee’s boundary-spanning behavior (BSB), thereby integrating the investigation of P – O fit and competitive intensity with a job-demands and resources conceptualization. In this regard, the current study makes two important contributions to the literature. First, prior P – O fit and BSB research is constructively extended. Although previous research has shown a relationship between P – O fit and an employee’s organizational citizenship behavior (Peng and Chiu, 2010; Cable and DeRue, 2002), no study has examined the contribution of P – O fit as an environmental resource (i.e. job resource) that facilitates the development of positive employee psychological states, while hampering the development of negative states.

Second, this research demonstrates that competitive intensity can be regarded as an environmental demand (i.e. job demand) that reduces employee achievement-striving motivation and decreases emotional exhaustion. Further, the current study maintains that emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation are proximal reactions to perceived fit with the organization and competitive intensity. It is proposed that a service employee’s perceived fit with his/her organization and contextual competitive intensity are key factors for explaining the achievement-striving motivation and emotional exhaustion linkages to BSBs. Based on these notions, an integrated model that combines P – O fit, competitive intensity, achievement-striving motivation and emotional exhaustion is presented (Figure 1).

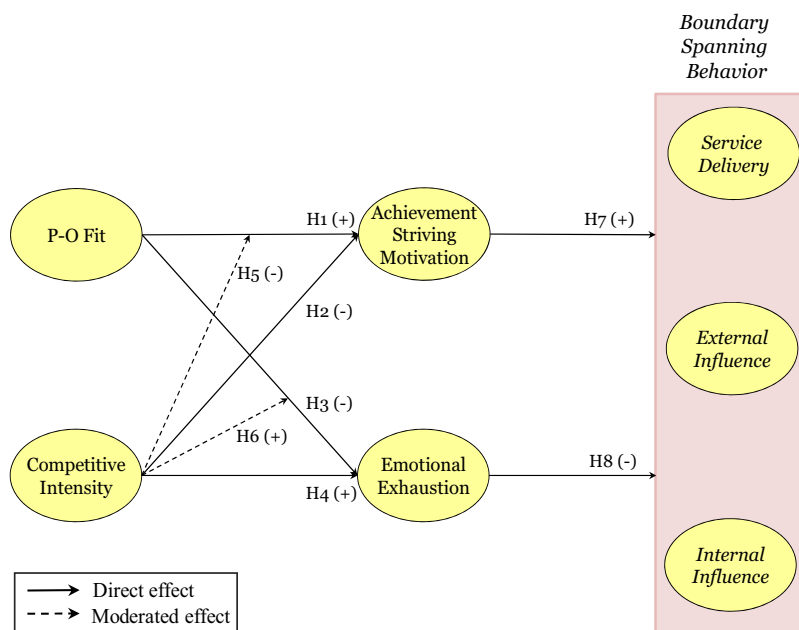


Figure 1.
Indirect effect of P – O fit
on BSB

Background theory

Job demands-resources model

In an occupational context, the JD-R model has highlighted the motivational and wellness-promoting potential of job-related resources (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007; Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). Although every occupation may have its own specific work characteristics associated with negative/positive employee outcomes such as exhaustion, burnout or achievement-striving, one central assumption of the JD-R model is that it is still possible to model these characteristics in relation to the interplay across two broad categories (i.e. job demands and job resources) (Bakker and Verbeke, 2004). *Job demands* are those physical, social or organizational aspects of the job that require sustained physical and/or psychological (i.e. cognitive or emotional) effort on the part of the employee. For example, completing highly involved projects on a tight time schedule, working toward the completion of multiple tasks simultaneously or having the performance of multiple other employees linked to one's own performance are all indicative of potentially high job demands. *Job resources* are physical, psychological, social or organizational aspects of the job that reduce the physiological and psychological costs associated with job demands; are functional in achieving work goals; and/or stimulate personal growth, learning and development (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). Hence, not only are resources necessary to deal with job demands, but they also are important in their own right (Hobfoll, 2002). In general, job demands and resources are negatively correlated because job demands, such as high work pressure and emotionally demanding workloads, may preclude the mobilization of job resources (Bakker *et al.*, 2003; Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). In a similar vein, high job resources, such as social support and feedback, may attenuate the effects of job demands.

Another important assumption in the JD-R model is that work characteristics may evoke two psychologically different processes. In the first process (i.e. strain), demanding aspects of work contribute to the development of feelings of constant overtaxing and, in the long run, exhaustion (Wright and Cropanzano, 1998). Exhaustion, in turn, may lead to negative consequences for the organization, such as absenteeism and impaired in-role performance (Bakker and Verbeke, 2004).

In the second process (i.e. motivational striving), job resources lead to engagement and positive outcomes (Schaufeli and Bakker, 2004). For instance, Bakker and Verbeke's (2004) study of human service professionals showed that job resources lead to dedication and extra-role performance. This is consistent with Leithwood *et al.* (1999), who suggest that schools may develop commitment to the collectively held goals of the organization by providing teachers with opportunities to become increasingly competent and by developing shared decision-making possibilities (i.e. job resources).

Research model and hypotheses

Incorporating the concepts of a JD-R model, the research model depicted in Figure 1 is proposed to investigate the effect of P – O fit (a job resource), competitive intensity (a job demand), emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation on service employee BSB (i.e. the link of psychological states to behaviors). As previously suggested, *P – O fit* is defined as the congruence of organizational and individual values, from the employee perspective (O'Reilly *et al.*, 1991). The direct and moderating role of competitive intensity as a job demand is investigated as a contextual influence between P – O fit and emotional exhaustion/achievement-striving motivation, as well as a direct influence upon exhaustion and motivation. Although JD-R theory suggests a potentially direct interaction of job demands and resources, previous research dealing specifically with environmental influences and P – O fit suggests such environmental influences would significantly affect, in a moderating fashion, the outcomes associated with P – O fit (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005). Further, previous service employee research investigating competitive intensity suggests the important moderating impact of the variable (Arnold *et al.*, 2009). As such, competitive intensity seems a critical job demand to investigate as a potential moderator.

The effects of JD-R constructs

The positive resource of P – O fit drives the first two hypotheses of our proposed model. The focus of the first hypothesis is upon P – O fit's influence upon a specific work motivation (i.e. achievement striving) rather than overall motivation. The influence of developing specific and challenging goals on task performance is well documented (Locke *et al.*, 1981). Colarelli *et al.* (1987) argue that individuals with goals to reach specific career objectives would be more likely to achieve those objectives than employees without such goals. Motivational constructs can thus be measured by first identifying basic goals that regulate personal behavior and then determining the arousal, intensity and persistence associated with those goals (Barrick *et al.*, 2002). Barrick *et al.* (2002) explain that a broadly applicable theory of work motivation requires the identification of a limited number of basic goals that regulate human behavior in the workplace.

Based on an employee's specific goal-striving desires, Barrick *et al.* (2002) provide the concept of achievement-striving motivation. Specifically, achievement-striving may

predispose individuals to respond more positively to task variety and to more effectively use helpful job resources, as these individuals prefer situations with task variety that challenge their abilities, enable them to work hard and take their work seriously (Hui *et al.*, 2010).

Relatedly, job resources can be defined as positively self-evaluated environmental conditions that reinforce an employee's sense of his/her ability to successfully control and impact an environment (Hobfoll, 1989). Employees who experience P – O fit will regard this perceived match as such a job resource (Schaufeli and van Rhenen, 2009). Schaufeli and van Rhenen (2009) suggest that, consistent with the motivational process of the JD-R model, work environments offer abundant resources that foster the willingness of employees to dedicate their efforts and abilities to the work task. In such environments, it is likely that the task will be completed successfully and that the work goal will be attained (Schaufeli and van Rhenen, 2009).

Further, previous research highlights that job resources, such as P – O fit, lead to engagement and positive outcomes (Schaufeli and Bakker, 2004). For instance, Bakker and Verbeke's (2004) study of human service professionals showed that job resources lead to dedication and extra-role performance. This is consistent with Leithwood *et al.* (1999), who suggest that P – O fit may elicit positive sentiments (e.g. trust, commitment and satisfaction) that, in turn, could motivate a person to achieve their task completely in the organization.

H1. P – O fit is positively related to achievement-striving motivation.

Conversely, the pattern of events related to emotional exhaustion is conceptually consistent with the conservation of resources perspective, that is, emotionally exhausted individuals should attempt to minimize further resource loss (Hobfoll, 1989) and, when unsuccessful, engage in withdrawal coping mechanisms (Cole *et al.*, 2010; Wright and Cropanzano, 1998). Employee perceptions of work-induced emotional exhaustion often occur when employees perform "people-work" of some kind (Cordes and Dougherty, 1993), where frequent interaction with persons external to the organization is a norm. Related to this, service professionals are required to promote the welfare of their clients, which imposes a variety of cognitive, emotional and behavioral demands (Jonge and Dormann, 2006). In service industries, the ongoing hassles and excessive customer demands can lead to feelings of both physical and emotional depletion (Wright and Cropanzano, 1998; Crosno *et al.*, 2009).

In the strain process, demanding aspects of work (i.e. time pressure, emotional workload, problems in physical work environment) are associated with resource loss, such as health problems and reduction of employee energy resources in the form of burnout (Wright and Cropanzano, 1998). On the other hand, previous research has demonstrated that P – O fit will negatively affect perceptions of emotional exhaustion (Singh and Greenhaus, 2004). According to Singh and Greenhaus (2004), stress is reduced when an employee feels that there is a close fit between him/herself and the organization (i.e. the positive job resource helps to minimize the strain process). An employee judging a match between his/her values and those of the organization is likely to sense an ability to control a given context, thus minimizing the perceived potential consequences of a job stressor and minimizing perceived stress (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005; Singh and Greenhaus, 2004).

H2. P – O fit is negatively related to perceptions of emotional exhaustion.

Competitive intensity is a job demand that may be associated with the development of environmental hostility within a service organization (Dess and Beard, 1984; Zahra and Covin, 1995). *Competitive intensity* can be defined as a situation where industry competition is fierce due to the number of competitors in the market and the lack of potential opportunities for further market growth. From the service employee perspective, competitive intensity can be regarded as a job demand placed upon them through their organization's demand for strong performance within a highly competitive industry. Indeed, as noted by Arnold *et al.* (2009), as well as Ramani and Kumar (2008), heightened competitive intensity places a managerial focus upon service employee performance and the provision of exceptional service. Because competition erodes the ability to differentiate based upon physical products, the increased emphasis upon service provision can alter managerial focus toward the differentiating potential of excellence in service provision (Arnold *et al.*, 2009), prompting managerial emphasis and expectation for exceptional service provision. As noted previously, however, when an already fatigued service employee is pressed for heightened performance, increased stress, as opposed to increased motivation, is the likely result. Therefore:

H3. Competitive intensity is negatively related to achievement-striving motivation.

Similarly, working within an environment characterized by high levels of industry competition, extra energy to compensate fatigue has to be mobilized through extended mental effort to maintain task performance. The mobilization of extra energy results in not only decreased motivation but also higher levels of emotional exhaustion.

H4. Competitive intensity is positively related to emotional exhaustion.

In addition to the main effects of a job resource (in this instance, P – O fit), the JD-R model proposes that the interaction between job demands and job resources is important for the development of job strain (emotional exhaustion) and motivation, as well. More specifically, it is proposed that job demands may moderate the impact of job resources in relation to the ultimate development of strain (negative) and motivation (positive) (Bakker and Verbeke, 2004). Which job demands and resources play the interactive role in an organization or occupation depends on the specific job characteristics that prevail. Indeed, the JD-R model posits that many different types of job resources/demands may interact to ultimately influence important outcomes (Bakker and Verbeke, 2004).

In this paper, in addition to the direct effect proposed in *H3* and *H4*, we also focus upon industry competitive intensity as a moderating job demand based on the interaction proposition of the JD-R model. In relation to such potential moderation, Bakker and Demerouti (2007) suggest a potentially negative effect of job demands in the positive relationship between job resources and motivation in their full JD-R-based model. Applied to achievement-striving motivation, the positive relationship between P – O fit and achievement-striving will be weaker for those facing the high-demand context associated with competitive intensity. That is, the current study proposes that in the absence of a competitive environment, service employees who perceive fit with the organization are more prone to achievement striving, while those under conditions of high competitive intensity have less striving motivation for task achievement because of demanding characteristics of the work environment.

H5. Competitive intensity will attenuate the positive relationship between P – O fit and achievement-striving motivation.

Applying the moderating influence of a competitive environment to the linkage between P – O Fit and emotional exhaustion, the negative relationship will be stronger for those in a high job demand context (i.e. high level of competitive intensity). This hypothesis is not only consistent with the job-demands resource model but is also consistent with demand – control and effort – reward imbalance models (Siegrist, 1996). That is, the negative relationship between a job resource, such as P – O fit, and strain will be multiplied when service employees are exposed to additional environmental demands. A heightened organizational focus upon the provision of exceptional service within a competitive industry would create such a context (Arnold *et al.*, 2009).

H6. Competitive intensity will strengthen the negative relationship between P – O fit and emotional exhaustion.

The effects of psychological states on boundary-spanning behaviors

As noted in the introduction, Bettencourt and Brown (2003) and Bettencourt *et al.* (2001) provide three types of BSBs frontline employees may perform associated with linking the organization to its positional or actual customers.

- (1) *Service delivery*: Serving customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible and courteous manner (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988).
- (2) *External representation*: Being vocal advocates to outsiders of the organization's image, goods and services (Bowen and Schneider 1985).
- (3) *Internal influence*: Taking individual initiative in communications to the firm and coworker to improve service delivery by the organization, coworkers and oneself (Schneider and Bowen, 1984; Zeithaml *et al.*, 1988).

Research relating achievement-striving motivation to Organizational Citizenship Behaviors (OCB) is surprisingly rare, yet there appears to be natural links between/ among the constructs. Oldham and Hackman (1981) argued that employees who are motivated in their jobs engage in higher levels of task performance because performing well creates positive affect. Staw (1977) made a similar argument, suggesting that motivated individuals derive satisfaction from task accomplishment and therefore work harder to excel. Tang and Ibrahim (1998) noted statistically significant relationships between achievement-striving motivation and organizational citizenship behavior.

Similarly, it is anticipated that service employees rate a feeling of accomplishment and performing work helpful to customers and other employees as a more important job characteristic than do other internal employees. Service employees who have needs for task achievement may have good relationships with others, and continue to work at the office to fulfill their tasks efficiently. That is, they want their organization be a good place to work, both present and future. They may not only be more concerned about the results of their task implementation and worried about whether goals are achieved but also more concerned about the task accomplishment of co-workers and organizational success. Thus, they may voluntarily help others with work-related problems, encourage others in the organization to achieve job performance and take on extra roles.

H7. Achievement-striving motivation is positively related to frontline employees' service delivery, external representation and internal influence.

A growing literature demonstrates the link between burnout and task performance (Cordes and Dougherty, 1993; Wright and Bonett, 1997; Wright and Cropanzano, 1998). Cordes and Dougherty (1993) propose that burnout leads to negative employee behaviors toward customers, work and the organization (e.g. diminished service quality; reduced degree of job involvement; or increased absenteeism, turnover and decreased task performance). Wright and Bonett (1997) find that emotional exhaustion is related negatively to task performance. Moreover, on the basis of conservation of resources theory, Wright and Cropanzano (1998) demonstrate that emotional exhaustion has a significant negative effect on task performance after controlling for the effects of positive and negative affectivity. Finally, Cropanzano *et al.* (2003) investigate the effects of emotional exhaustion on employees' pro-social behavior based on social exchange theory, and find similarly negative effects upon outcomes.

Based on these results, it is likely that to maintain emotional balance, frontline employees who experience emotional exhaustion will reduce their BSBs.

H8. Emotional exhaustion is negatively related to frontline employees' service delivery, external representation and internal influence.

Method

Measures

All measures are adapted or developed based upon prior research. Individual measurement items for the constructs are listed in Table AI. P – O fit was assessed using a scale developed by Netemeyer *et al.* (1997) that measures the congruence of the values of an individual employee with the perceived values of his/her organization (i.e. P – O fit based on employee perceptions of this fit). Four items asked service workers to assess the fit between their personal values and the organization's values. The items are evaluated on five-point scales ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree."

To measure competitive intensity, a scale from Pelham and Wilson (1996) was used. The competitive intensity scale includes three questions that are scored on a seven-point frequency scale ranging from "not threatening" to "very threatening"

To measure employee emotional exhaustion, Maslach and Jackson's (1981) emotional exhaustion subscale (a component of burnout) was used. The emotional exhaustion subscale includes nine questions that are scored on a seven-point frequency scale ranging from "never" to "daily". Achievement-striving motivation was measured with the Halbesleben and Bowler (2007) scale. This scale was based on the Motivation Orientation Inventory (Barrick *et al.*, 2002). Achievement-striving motivation is measured with eleven items that are scored on a 7-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree).

Bettencourt and MacKenzie (2005) developed the BSB measure based on their conceptual definitions and prior research involving measurement of related pro-social behavior and/or service quality constructs. External representation is measured using a four-item scale designed to tap the extent to which an employee is a vocal advocate to outsiders of his/her organization's image, goods and services. Internal influence is measured with a four-item scale intended to capture the extent to which a person takes individual initiative in communicating to the firm and coworkers about ways to improve service delivery by the organization, coworkers and oneself. Service delivery is measured with a five-item scale that reflects the extent to which the employee serves customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible and courteous manner.

Sampling procedure and data collection

Data for the study were collected from a cross-sectional sample of retail bank frontline service employees in South Korea. Participation was solicited from various large banks across the country. All organizations involved in the data collection offer services and sell service products to customers directly.

The instrument was prepared in English and then translated into Korean. It was checked for accuracy in line with the conventional back-translation process. Data were collected on-site from each participating bank. The sample for the study was drawn with the help of chief executive officers (CEOs) who worked for ten top-ranked banks with headquarters in Seoul. In the initial contact, a coverletter was mailed explaining the purpose of the survey to the CEO, who was asked to persuade his branch managers to participate in the survey. Four of ten CEOs agreed to ask branch managers to participate in the survey. Based on the list of branches then suggested by CEOs, branch managers were asked to help with the survey administration.

An interviewer scheduled appointments with the branch manager as an informant, who then introduced the interviewer to the other employees in that branch. The interviewer presented the respondents with the survey questionnaire and collected the questionnaire upon completion. Data were collected solely from branch employees and not branch managers (and design effects were not indicative of nested data). Respondents were motivated by assuring them of confidentiality and by offering a \$2 value phone card.

Sample characteristics

Questionnaires were distributed to 500 frontline employees across several banks. Of these, 346 usable questionnaires were returned, for a response rate of 69.2 per cent (interviewer presence certainly aided this response rate). The employee sample is 49 per cent male, with an average age of 35 years, ten-year tenure in the current position and 68.6 per cent of the sample has a university degree.

Research findings

Demographic control variables

Wright and Bonett (1997) underscore the fact that different demographic groups may be differentially impacted by variables such as emotional exhaustion. For this reason, we controlled for age and gender in all of hypothesis tests. In this research, gender and age were collected as categorical variables. Therefore, before including these control variables into testing analyses, significant difference tests of emotional exhaustion (nine items) on gender and age were conducted. Results showed that there was no significant difference of emotional exhaustion on age and gender categories. Thus, these two demographic variables were not included in the formal hypothesis testing analysis[1].

Measurement model analysis and results

To analyze the data, a structural equation model procedure using LISREL 8.5 was used (Jöreskog and Sörbom, 1996). Reliabilities of the individual measurement scales were assessed using Cronbach's coefficient α and Fornell and Larcker's (1981) composite reliability formula. Average variance extracted, composite reliability calculations and items appear in Table AI. The measurement model in this study consists of 40 reflective indicators and seven correlated latent factors corresponding to the seven constructs of the study depicted in Figure 1.

The first step in the analysis was to test the hypothesized measurement relationships and evaluate the reliability and discriminant validity of the constructs. To do this, a seven-construct confirmatory factor analysis was estimated using the covariance matrix as input. Overall, the confirmatory factor model fit the data very well. The chi-square (df) was 419.12 (168), the comparative fit index (CFI) was 0.98, the root mean squared error approximation (RMSEA) was 0.056, the normed fit index (NFI) was 0.97, root mean square residual (RMR) was 0.069 and goodness of fit index (GFI) was 0.92.

As indicated in Table I, the Cronbach alpha reliability estimates were all well above Nunnally's (1978) recommended level of 0.70. Fornell and Larcker's (1981) index of the average amount of variance each latent factor accounted for in its indicators ($\rho_{vc}(\eta)$) was well above the recommended level of 0.50 for all of the constructs in Table AI. Evidence of discriminant validity is provided by the fact that all of the construct intercorrelations were significantly ($p < 0.05$) less than 1.00; and the variance shared by any two constructs (i.e. the square of their intercorrelation) was always less than the $\rho_{vc}(\eta)$'s for the constructs.

To assess the potential common method bias, we applied the "MV" marker method and used a scale theoretically unrelated to at least one scale in the analysis as the method variance (MV) marker, which offered a proxy for common method variance (Lindell and Whitney 2001). We used a five-item scale that measured the subject's perceived family meal importance (Putrevu and Ratchford, 1997 Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.77$) and selected lowest positive correlation ($r = 0.027$) between MV marker and other variables to adjust the construct correlation and statistical significance (Lindell and Whitney, 2001). None of the significant correlations became insignificant after adjustment (Table II). Therefore, common method bias was unlikely to be a serious concern.

Results and analysis

We tested the hypotheses proposed herein using structural equation modeling with LISREL 8.5 (Jöreskog and Sörbom, 1996). The overall fit of this model was good. The chi-square (df) was 1,268.48 (198), CFI was 0.93, RFI was 0.0.90 and NFI was 0.92. The structural estimates of this model are shown in Table II. As shown, the analyses provide support for most hypothesized relationships (with H7 and H8 having three components, respectively) except the link between emotional exhaustion and service delivery.

Table I.
Measure correlations,
average variance
extracted and composite
reliability

	P-O fit	ASM	EE	CI	SD	ER	II	Cronbach alpha	CR	AVE
P-O fit		0.396*	-0.193*	0.050	0.617*	0.675*	0.527*	0.907	0.915	0.785
ASM	0.412*		0.045	-0.153*	0.538*	0.359*	0.494*	0.941	0.906	0.707
EE	-0.161*	0.071		0.124*	-0.031	-0.177*	-0.100	0.846	0.877	0.704
CI	0.076	-0.176*	0.148*		0.151	0.010	0.105*	0.852	0.862	0.678
SD	0.627*	0.550*	-0.003	0.174*		0.536*	0.751*	0.874	0.792	0.563
ER	0.684*	0.376*	-0.145*	0.037	0.549*		0.533*	0.916	0.919	0.793
II	0.540*	0.508*	-0.070	0.129*	0.758*	0.546*		0.896	0.935	0.769
MV	-0.017	-0.00	0.134*	0.139*	0.057	0.069	0.027	0.770		

Notes: P-O fit, person organization fit; ASM, achievement striving motivation; EE, emotional exhaustion; CI, competitive intensity; SD, Service delivery; ER, external representation; II, internal influence; MV, MV marker; *significant at < 0.01

Hypothesized relationships	Unstandardized estimates	t-value	SE	Conclusion
Person organization fit → achievement striving motivation	0.55	11.25	0.05	<i>H1</i> supported
Person organization fit → emotional exhaustion	−0.13	−2.44	0.05	<i>H2</i> supported
Competitive intensity → achievement striving motivation	−0.13	−2.91	0.04	<i>H3</i> supported
Competitive intensity → emotional exhaustion	−0.05	−0.99	0.05	<i>H4</i> not supported
Achievement striving motivation → service delivery	0.73	13.33	0.05	<i>H7a</i> supported
Achievement striving motivation → external representation	0.52	10.62	0.05	<i>H7b</i> supported
Achievement striving motivation → internal influence	0.64	0.05	12.48	<i>H7c</i> supported
Emotional exhaustion → service delivery	−0.06	−1.41	0.04	<i>H8a</i> not supported
Emotional exhaustion → external representation	−0.17	−3.82	0.04	<i>H8b</i> supported
Emotional exhaustion → internal influence	−0.10	−2.36	0.04	<i>H8c</i> supported

Table II.
Result of hypothesized relationships

H1 and *H2* pertain to P–O fit and its influence on achievement-striving motivation and emotional exhaustion. The results indicate that P–O fit for frontline employees exhibits the predicted positive influence on achievement-striving motivation (standardized coefficient value of 0.55, $p < 0.01$), as well as the predicted negative effect on emotional exhaustion (-0.13 , $p < 0.01$).

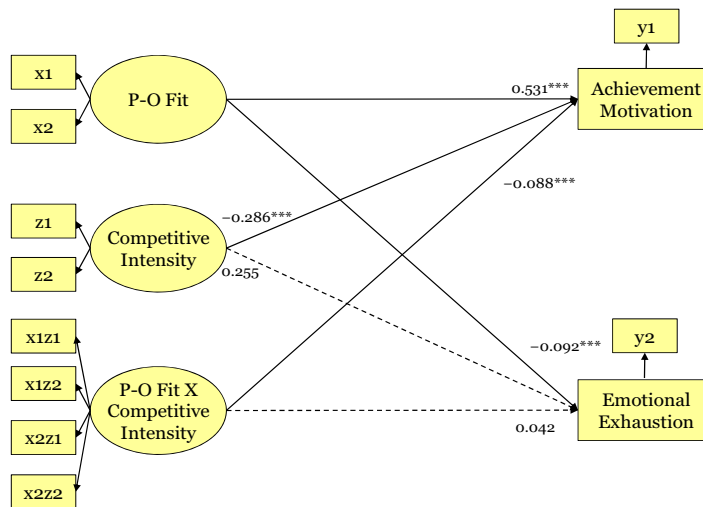
H3 and *H4* relate to competitive intensity and its effect on achievement-striving motivation and emotional exhaustion. The results indicate that competitive intensity for frontline employees exhibits the expected negative influence on achievement-striving motivation (standardized coefficient value of -0.13 , $p < 0.01$). However, competitive intensity has no significant effect on emotional exhaustion (-0.05 , $p > 0.1$). Thus, *H4* was not supported.

In addition, the influence of frontline employee achievement-striving motivation on BSB was tested. *H7a*, *H7b* and *H7c* are the hypotheses involving employee's achievement-striving motivation. The results show that all components of *H7* are supported ($p < 0.01$). Achievement-striving has a positive, significant influence on service delivery (0.73), external representation (0.52) and internal influence (0.64).

The results indicate that emotional exhaustion has no negative influence on a frontline employee's service delivery (standardized coefficient value of -0.06 , $p > 0.01$). However, emotional exhaustion negatively relates to external representation (-0.17 , $p < 0.01$) and internal influence (-0.10 , $p < 0.01$). Thus, among *H6a*, *H6b* and *H6c*, only *H6a* is rejected.

Moderating effects of competitive intensity

To estimate the effects of an interaction variable identified as "P–O fit *competitive intensity" in AMOS, we utilized a two-step estimation approach suggested by Ping (1995) for modeling form moderation (results demonstrated in Figure 2). This approach



Notes: *** significant at < 0.01

Figure 2.
Results of latent
interaction model

involves calculating the loading and error variance for the two indicators of the latent product using measurement model parameter estimates, and then fixing the loading and error variance at their calculated values in the structural model. We next explain the steps involved in the interaction analysis.

The first step was to center the variables, P – O fit, competitive intensity, achievement-striving motivation and emotional exhaustion by replacing their raw scores with deviation scores. After centering the variables, we summed the indicators of latent endogenous variables (achievement-striving motivation and emotional exhaustion) to form the latent product. We also parceled and summed the two indicators of latent exogenous variables (P – O fit and emotional exhaustion), as shown in Figure 2. The two measurement items for P – O fit and competitive intensity were multiplied to form the four indicators of the latent product (P – O fit *competitive intensity).

Figure 2 shows the results of the moderating hypotheses. *H5* posits that the P – O fit linkage to achievement-striving motivation will be attenuated when competitive intensity is perceived to be high, which was confirmed ($t = -3.364$ $p < 0.01$). Thus, competitive intensity appears to attenuate the positive relationship between P – O fit and achievement-striving motivation.

H6 posits that the negative relationship between P – O fit and emotional exhaustion will be reinforced when competitive intensity is strong. However, the results showed that the interaction term of P – O fit and competitive intensity is not significantly related to emotional exhaustion ($t = -1.461$ $p > 0.05$). Thus, *H6* is rejected.

Discussion

General discussion of results

This study extends prior research from Bettencourt and Brown (2003) and Bettencourt *et al.* (2001) by linking the relationship between P – O fit and BSB with employee psychological states (i.e. emotional exhaustion and achievement-striving motivation).

With regard to the outcomes of P – O fit, this research finds that an employee's perceived fit with his/her organization enhances achievement-striving motivation and reduces emotional exhaustion. In relation to the outcomes of competitive intensity, results show that working within a highly competitive industry negatively influences a service employee's achievement-striving motivation, while having no influence upon emotional exhaustion. These two psychological processes of JD-R mechanisms, in turn, increase employee BSB (in the case of achievement striving), while negatively influencing elements of BSB (in the case of emotional exhaustion). The results reinforce the notion that P – O fit and competitive intensity are important factors affecting employee motivation, affect and attachment (O'Reilly *et al.*, 1991), and extend such an understanding to a purely service-based environment among frontline employees. Such an understanding demonstrates the significance of properly aligned employment, at least in relation to matching values, in a service setting. Consequently, low demand and high resource conditions are likely to result in high motivation and low strain, while high demand and low resource conditions have, as a consequence, high strain and low motivation.

Research investigating the underlying mechanisms between frontline employee P – O fit and BSB is limited, prompting Podsakoff *et al.* (2000) to suggest that future research should further map the relationships among the antecedents to BSB. To answer Podsakoff *et al.*'s (2000) call, the present study not only investigates the linking mechanisms between service employee P – O fit and BSB (as discussed above) but also highlights the relationships among these antecedent variables of BSB. Specifically, a values compatible work environment fosters the productive behavior of achievement-striving motivation, while mitigating the development of negative judgments of work-related emotional exhaustion.

The literature investigating antecedents to BSB is further expanded by the mediating model presented in this study. Research linking achievement-striving motivation to OCB-type constructs is surprisingly rare. According to the Chiu and Tsai (2006), a sense of personal accomplishment signifies that a job offers a personal challenge or personal interest to the point that an employee is willing to work in this job environment and is willing to display organizational citizenship behavior. The findings of this study confirm the viewpoint of Chiu and Tsai (2006) and demonstrate a positive relationship between accomplishment striving and BSB.

Further, the current results are consistent with the demand-control model. Thus, the findings suggest that instead of directly affecting BSBs, job resources indirectly affect BSBs via increased levels of achievement-striving motivation. On a more general level, this supports Hackman and Oldham's (1980) Job Characteristics Theory that assumes that critical psychological states (i.e. meaningfulness, responsibility and knowledge of the results) mediate job characteristics (i.e. resources such as variety, task identity, task significance, autonomy and feedback) and outcomes (i.e. motivated proactive behavior).

Next, when job resources increase, emotional exhaustion tends to decrease as well (H2). According to Schaufeli and Bakker (2004), job resources may play an extrinsic motivational role because they are instrumental in achieving work goals. Because, according to the effort-recovery model (Meijman and Mulder, 1998), work environments that offer many resources foster the willingness to dedicate one's efforts and abilities to the work task. Thus, the results confirm the role of P – O fit in predicting service employee emotional exhaustion.

Contrary to *H4*, working within a competitive industry environment did not significantly affect emotional exhaustion. In combination with the lack of an interactive effect between P – O fit and competitive intensity upon emotional exhaustion, it seems apparent that working within a competitive industry environment is not a primary driver of worker fatigue. This is potentially conflictive with previous findings (e.g. [Arnold et al., 2009](#)) where it is indicated that a competitive environment influences managerial emphasis upon heightened service provision (a potential contributor to stress and exhaustion among service personnel). Although the exact nature of such a process relationship was not tested within this context, it seems a potentially fruitful avenue of future research to investigate contextual differences that might heighten the influence of competitive intensity. Given that [Arnold et al. \(2009\)](#) found their results within a US context, and the current study is within South Korea, there may be cultural factors that influence managerial reaction to a competitive environment in relation to employee management. At least given the current findings, it appears that a US context potentially translates competitive intensity into a stressful employee environment, while competitive intensity in a South Korean context has little effect upon employee strain. Obviously, however, future research would need to verify such a claim.

In relation to emotional exhaustion, as expected, the results of this study demonstrate that emotional exhaustion has a negative relationship to external representation and internal influence, which indicates that frontline employees with a greater judgment of work-induced emotional exhaustion are less willing to display positive behaviors (*H8b and H8c*). According to [Bettencourt and Brown \(2003\)](#), for the majority of frontline employees, service delivery behaviors are likely to be relatively more role prescribed due to their frequent specification in job descriptions, training materials and performance evaluation forms. However, external representation and internal influence behaviors are likely to be relatively more discretionary ([Bettencourt and Brown, 2003](#)). Thus, inference indicates that emotional exhaustion is more related to frontline employee discretionary behaviors.

In addition to the main effects of job resources, the JD-R model proposes that the interaction between job demands and job resources is important for the development of judgments of strain and motivated behaviors (also consistent with the importance placed upon contextual moderators in P – O fit research – [Kristof-Brown et al., 2005](#)). In this research, the findings suggest that competitive intensity (environmental job demand) weakens the impact of service employee P – O fit (environmental job resource) on achievement-striving (*H5*). However, as noted, there is no significant moderating effect of competitive intensity on the link between P – O fit and emotional exhaustion. The non-significant interaction, as well as non-significant main effect of competitive intensity upon exhaustion, may be attributable to the specific resources and demands in the current study (such as culture), as well as the type of job positions that were investigated. Note, however, that other studies on the interaction, specifically, proposed by the JD-R model have similarly failed to produce significant results ([Bakker and Verbeke, 2004](#)). This implies that job demands, such as competitive intensity, appear to have a limited capability to influence the impact of job resources (P – O fit) on emotional exhaustion, which again suggests the overall significance of P – O fit to employee well-being (i.e. buffering negative outcomes).

Still, in relation to positive outcomes of P – O fit, the results suggest that increased job demands may actually dampen employee enthusiasm, even in a well-fit job placement.

Given the insignificant results of Bakker and Verbeke (2004), this may be a unique experience within a service context. The result implies that job demands may dampen the positive effect of job resources, potentially even in very well-managed organization (i.e. where P – O fit is high). Certainly, future research needs to further investigate the interactive effects of job demands and job resources, especially within service environments. Further, a deeper investigation of the potential effects of industry environment to the management of frontline employees is warranted.

Managerial implications

This research also has implications for management practice with respect to the benefit of P – O fit, achievement-striving motivation, occupational stress and BSB. This study demonstrates that P – O fit can make a difference to frontline employee motivation and emotional exhaustion. As such, in situations where employee values do not fit organizational values, frontline employees show low achievement striving and high emotional exhaustion. These results suggest that organizations have to do their best to manage P – O fit, most practically through employee screening or training and workshops to try and align organizational and employee values and objectives. For example, from a practical point of view, one could argue that employees apparently are very sensitive to the general perceptions of their work group. Social information processing research has convincingly demonstrated that employees' perceptions can be influenced through the communication and behaviors of their supervisors. Because supervisors determine organizational values and norms (Greenberg, 1990), leadership plays an important role in influencing employee perceptions (Aquino *et al.*, 1999). If managers of organizations are positively evaluated by the employees, it will be easier for them to "give things of value to followers (employees), such as sense of direction, values, and recognition, and receive other things in return such as esteem and responsiveness" (Hollander, 1987, p. 16). Such a statement underscores, of course, a leader's role in helping to develop a context that motivates employees, which then works to facilitate managerial directives. Further, the findings support the suggestion that organizational leaders are not only able to manage employee experiences but also their fit with the organization (Van Vianen *et al.*, 2007).

In this research the importance of psychological variables for predicting employee behaviors is highlighted. Thus, even if a manager cannot control employee P – O fit, this research suggests that a focus on reducing emotional exhaustion and enhancing achievement-striving motivation seems optimal. Even in situations where emotional exhaustion cannot be reduced, organizations may still influence frontline behaviors through achievement-striving motivation. Motivation theorists have suggested a multiplicity of mechanisms for increasing motivation, including increasing equity perceptions (Adams, 1963), increasing linkages among ability perceptions, reward attainability and the value of the rewards (Vroom, 1964) or appropriate job design (Hackman and Oldham, 1976), among others.

The current findings also suggest that no job resource is universally superior, regardless of environmental context. Managerial attention is drawn to the idea that the critical role of P – O fit on service employee's achievement-striving may vary across the different levels of competitive intensity. Managers should be aware of the complex and contingent processes of employee's achievement-striving motivation to fully

comprehend the impact of P – O fit on employee's BSB through different levels of competitive environmental contexts.

Limitation and future research

This study suffers from common limitations of cross-sectional field research, including the inability to make causal inferences. First, although the study investigates a structural model of relationships among variables, one can only conclude that the model is a feasible explanation of the observed relationships in the data. The direction of paths in the model relies on prior research.

Second, the study investigates a theoretical model using various banks in South Korea, but the generalizability of the findings beyond this context relies on additional research. Further, recent research by Donavan *et al.* (2004) suggests that it also would be worthwhile to consider individual customer orientation as an antecedent to frontline employee BSB. Further, ultimate outcome variables beyond the employee reporting of BSBs would strengthen research related to this topic. While it is certainly important to understand the process of development related to BSB, the key effect is found in customer observations related to such behaviors. An interesting extension of the current work would include the investigation of BSB as a mediator to such variables as customer satisfaction, service quality perceptions, and/or average margin/service return.

Third, the critical role of P – O fit on employee's BSB was examined but did not incorporate the impact of other job resources to understand the process of employee's psychological aspects more thoroughly. Similarly, competitive intensity was the representation of job demands, without consideration of further potentially impactful demand factor. For future research, specific types of job resources and demands which are unique to service employees could be added. Such resources might include customer orientation, perceived fit with customer or customer support, to better understand the effect of job resources on frontline employees' motivation and/or burnout and job demands such as a direct measure of managerial expectations for increased performance or increased customer crowding. In addition, in a similar vein as point two made above, multi-level data that incorporates both manager and customer data would allow for a more complete understanding of the interplay between job resources/demands and customer perceptions of both the frontline employee, as well as the organization.

Note

1. Tables available upon request to lead author.

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